

dynamics need to be in sync. Thus, a bullish consumption trend is essential for the growth of the FOSS ecosystem. Where does India stand on the FOSS consumption front? We do have an expanding base of consumers, ranging from the government, big enterprises and SMEs spanning across verticals like retail, BFSI and manufacturing. Yet, issues like inadequate advocacy and unsatisfactory government support remain a hindrance to wide-scale FOSS adoption in India.

Overcoming advocacy shortcomings

Appropriate advocacy is essential for the success of FOSS and its ecosystem. In India, most users like developers and hobbyists are attracted to FOSS because it is free of cost, and not for its benefits like software freedom, opportunities for collaboration and participation, etc. "Open source is still equated with 'free' instead of 'freedom', in India. With awareness levels still being low, one isn't sure whether the ecosystem has grown out of this nascent stage," says Naveen Shenoy, MD and founder, Shenoy Systems. In a country where pirated copies of proprietary software are freely available, the 'free of cost' argument of FOSS is not a strong one, feels Bhavsar, who says there is need for proper advocacy to build consumer confidence related to the use of FOSS.

But how does one develop smart and strong advocacy around FOSS? To build up a local ecosystem of

supporting organisations and businesses, the benefits of open source need to be communicated effectively. And the benefits stretch beyond lower or no licensing costs, to include direct access to programmers for mentoring, review, feature requests, innovation, better security, and access to source code. Take Zynga, for instance: it serves games to around 250 million users a month, and the amount of data transferred per day is close to two petabytes, i.e., data content of about 32 lakh video CDs put together. Zynga chose open source software since proprietary technology could not scale to the needs of its ever growing user base and also innovate at the pace required to be the leader in the social gaming market. To sustain the huge scale of data transfer, it switched to FOSS, which gave it flexibility and scalability without any performance issues. Such success stories need to be highlighted to boost the spread of FOSS.

Bacche, however, feels the advocacy limitation at another level. "Though customers in India are changing their vision of open source software, acknowledging benefits other than costs, the lack of independent software vendors (ISVs) is hampering consumption. There is a need for a governance model around FOSS especially when it comes to understanding licenses and integration issues. Advocacy at this level is needed to help consumers adopt software smoothly," says Bacche.

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